SEA BATTLES IN NORTHERN EUROPE

DURING THE PERIOD of almost half a millennium between the Norman invasion of England in 1066 and the loss of the English "Great Ship" *Mary Rose* in the Solent in 1545, naval warfare in northern Europe underwent decisive technological changes. The Normans crossed the Channel in vessels resembling Viking longships; by the 16th century war fleets included large three- and four-masted carracks armed with cannon. But the place of sea power in north European warfare remained relatively constant. It enabled states to conduct coastal raids or to land troops and horses for larger scale military incursions. Naval matters were most important to the English kings, who needed to ferry armies to the European mainland where they possessed or claimed substantial territories, and also depended on the Channel to protect them from attack by continental armies. Rivalry between the kings of France and England, at its fiercest during the Hundred Years War (1337–1453), was at the root of most naval conflicts in the region. Permanent navies were slow to emerge, however, limiting the scale and frequency of sea warfare.

THE NORMAN INVASION OF ENGLAND

In 1066 Anglo-Saxon England was the target of no less than three seaborne attacks, all concerned with contesting the accession to the Anglo-Saxon throne of Harold Godwinson at the start of the year. In May Harold's exiled brother Tostig landed on the Isle of Wight with a fleet from Flanders and went on to raid Harold's main naval base at Sandwich. In early September a fleet of some 300 ships commanded by Norwegian King Harald Hardrada, with Tostig as his ally, landed an army in northern England. This invasion failed because King Harold defeated King Harald's land forces at Stamford Bridge. The third seaborne operation, mounted by William Duke of Normandy, was a resounding success.

DAUNTING LOGISTICS

Whatever the merits of William's claim to the English throne, his preparations were thorough and determined. William had to transport an army of 7,000 men or more, along with some 2,000 horses, and equipment that included the components for a prefabricated wooden fort. At Dives-sur-Mer on the Normandy coast he assembled a fleet that has been estimated at around 700 ships. Some of these were built from scratch, a process shown in the Bayeux Tapestry. Most of the ships were probably much broader in the beam and deeper in draft than a Viking longship. It has been estimated that one such ship would have taken a team of 12 shipwrights three months to build. Given the scale of the enterprise, most vessels must surely have been existing craft supplied by the duke's seagoing subjects.

The fleet was ready by August 12, but the weather would not cooperate and a north wind kept the ships firmly bottled up in harbor for a month. On September 12, the fleet moved to St Valéry-sur-Somme, losing several ships en route through stormy weather. This placed William's invasion force closer to England, enabling him to target a landing site nearer London. King Harold was well informed of William's preparations and waited with his own ships and army on England's south coast. The long delay worked against Harold, however. Firstly, on September 8, most of his forces were sent home. Then the invasion by Harald Hardrada required a hasty march



Norman helmet
Standard equipment of the Norman knights that crossed the Channel in 1066 was chainmail armor and an iron helmet with a distinctive nose guard.



The invasion fleet
The Bayeux Tapestry includes a fairly faithful representation of William's ships, especially the sails, stays, and steering oars. Less realistic is the method shown of transporting horses.